



Entangled Itineraries

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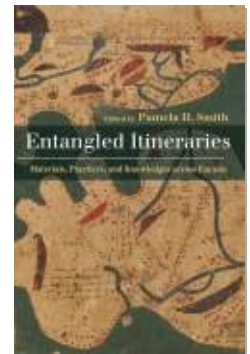
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Itineraries of Images

Agents of Integration in the Buddhist Cosmopolis

Tansen Sen

Tracking the movements of objects over long distances, and sometimes over the *longue durée*, reveals the inadequacies of limiting studies of “connectivities” or “border crossings” to a specific region or subregion. The broader geographical space within which such connections or interactions took place must be taken into account in order to comprehend the complex and accretive ways in which objects and ideas moved. In order to follow such itineraries, we should think beyond models of linear diffusion and examine the ways in which objects continued to move, even when the people who first carried them ceased to travel. These itineraries were recurrent movements in which several different groups of people participated in sometimes subtly and sometimes drastically transforming itinerant objects. Objects and ideas on some occasions filtered back transformed, often unrecognizable, to their nodes of origin. Moreover, circulating objects generated knowledge across the routes they traversed, triggered the movement of people, and shaped the material cultures of societies at multiple locations.

The spread of Buddhism initiated a flow of texts, ritual objects, images, artistic traditions, and languages over long distances. It also facilitated the congregation of people from different regions and varied traditions at urban centers, oasis states, and port cities. These movements and congregations led to the creation of new ideas, modifications of artistic traditions, and a broader dispersal of concepts and designs. State patronage, the proselytizing zeal of large monastic institutions, pilgrimage activities, and the spiritual needs of itinerant traders were the underlying features that nurtured the successful transmissions of Buddhism across most of the Asian continent. A noteworthy aspect of these Buddhist transmissions was the relative ease with which doc-

trines and other aspects of the religion underwent transformations so as to fit the preconceptions and needs of new groups of people. As a result Buddhist texts, artistic traditions, and the languages used to proselytize the doctrine differed from region to region. Many of these regions also created their own doctrinal emphasis and their own pilgrimage and transmission centers. Thus while Islam promoted universalism through a single sacred text and pilgrimage site, Buddhism offered multiple options with regard to both. The spread of Buddhism was not a simple unidirectional diffusion of ideas, beliefs, and objects. Rather, it was a multidirectional process within a cosmopolitan space and faith, which continuously evolved and expanded as it gathered in multiple groups of people, polities, languages, ritual objects, and interpretations.¹

Unlike Sheldon Pollock's Sanskrit cosmopolis, which encompassed South and Southeast Asia,² the world of the Buddhists—which included monks, lay believers, translators, and artists, as well as “opportunistic” rulers and traders—was significantly larger, more diverse, and involved more discourses, dialogues, and debates among people from varied regions. This diversity made Buddhism one of the most multifaceted religions, with numerous different ways to practice devotion and express faith, with a wide array of culture or subculture specific images, iconographies, and cosmologies and generative of enormous corpuses of texts in several different languages. The focus of this essay is on ways in which the movement of Buddhist images helped integrate widely separated regions of Asia and created a sense of common identity among the Buddhist followers living in different cultural zones despite significant transformations and reinterpretations in the material objects themselves.³ It is argued that the itineraries of images were crucial in creating and sustaining linkages within the Buddhist cosmopolis for over a millennium and half.⁴ While the connections between South Asia and China are at the center of this focus, discussion of other parts of Asia is included to demonstrate the intra-Asian linkages associated with the movement of Buddhist images.⁵

Buddhist Images on the Move

It is doubtful, as was contended by European scholars in the nineteenth century, that the earliest anthropomorphic images of the Buddha emerged only under Hellenistic influences.⁶ It is clear, however, that Greek artistic traditions and beliefs had discernible influence on the style and motifs found in early Buddhist art, especially those that emerged in the Gandhāra region (present-day Afghanistan/Pakistan). The location and date of the earliest

Buddha image remains under debate, with Robert DeCaroli noting that the date—which ranges from the first–second century BCE to the first century CE—is “far less controversial than their location. In part, this is because location is closely tied to the issues of identity, cultural diffusion, and political control that have run as an undercurrent through this debate.”⁷ DeCaroli points out that the early images of the Buddha were of a “transregional” style common to artists in both the Mathurā (in present-day Uttar Pradesh state in northern India) and Gandhāra regions.

Art forms representing Buddhist teachings and alluding to the life of the Buddha also began appearing between the first–second century BCE and the first century CE. These “aniconic” depictions, which DeCaroli defines as “a loose custom or preference by which the representation of certain categories of figures were to be avoided and in which anthropomorphic figural art held a potency beyond that of mere symbols,” emerged at some of the key Buddhist sites, including in Sāñcī (in the present-day Madhya Pradesh state of India).⁸ Images of donor figures depicted on inscriptions at several monastic institutions in the Gangetic region were the third type of motif that developed during this period. Gregory Schopen has argued that monks and nuns were instrumental in the creation of the so-called cult of images that popularized these donor images and subsequently propagated the figural representations of the Buddha within a monastic context.⁹

The Kuṣāṇa reign in Central Asia and northern India during the first two centuries CE contributed to the flourishing of several art forms, including figural representations of the rulers in several media such as coins and stones. DeCaroli argues that the Kuṣāṇas “introduced the new social customs that allowed for this type of artwork to be used in a wider range of contexts.”¹⁰ State patronage not only augmented the production of the portraiture and figural images of the rulers but also influenced the artistic traditions of Brahmanism, Jainism, and Buddhism. A similar trend took place in the Deccan region of India, where the Śātavāhana rulers (first century BCE to second century CE), almost at the same time as the Kuṣāṇas, patronized the production of art forms leading to a wider impact on the local artistic traditions.¹¹ During the reigns of the Kuṣāṇas and the Śātavāhanas the first images associated with Buddhism began to spread beyond South Asia through overland and maritime routes.

Buddhist images—including small portable statues of the Buddha, Buddhist divinities, and replicas of renowned temples (especially the Mahābodhi

Temple in Bodhgayā); talismans and votive tablets; and paintings that narrated the previous lives of the Buddha—often played a critical role in the early spread of Buddhist doctrines, as they seem to have moved over long distances even before the transmission of the doctrines and the exposition of relevant philosophical ideas.¹² Images were often the main media through which most lay believers encountered, understood, and practiced Buddhism. These things were carried by merchants, missionaries, pilgrims, and other itinerant travelers. During the first and second centuries CE, members of the Sogdian and Parthian merchant communities, originating in regions of present-day Tajikistan, Afghanistan, and Iran, were the foremost transmitters of Buddhist images to China. The Kuṣāṇa Empire greatly facilitated the movement of these merchant groups between South Asia and Han China, and with them Buddhist images and doctrines.

The role of merchant groups is hardly acknowledged in Chinese texts concerning the initial transmission of Buddhism. Rather, the most famous Chinese legend associated with the introduction of Buddhism into the region revolves around the Han Emperor Ming's 漢明帝 (r. 58–75) dream of a golden man, with a halo around his head, who flew into the imperial palace. On his inquiring about the possible meaning, his officials explained that the dream was probably about the Buddha, who was venerated in the "Western Regions." Emperor Ming soon dispatched envoys to bring to Han China people who could explain the teachings of this "sage of the West." The Han envoys returned in the year 67 CE with the first two "Indian" monks named Jiaye Modeng 迦葉摩騰 (Kāśyapa Mātanga?) and Zhu Falan 竺法蘭 (Dharmaratna?). These two monks are credited for initiating the translation of Buddhist texts at the imperially funded "first" Buddhist monastery in East Asia known as the Baima si 白馬寺 (White Horse Monastery). This story of an official transmission of Buddhism was composed two to three centuries after Buddhist doctrines and images first entered Han China, with the objective of legitimizing the transmission of the foreign religion by inventing a role for the Chinese emperor in the process.¹³

Archaeological evidence suggests a more random transmission of Buddhism and one that seems to have been more integrated with local beliefs from an early stage. The images found engraved on Mount Kongwang 孔望山 in the coastal area of Jiangsu province are examples of this phenomenon. Dating from the second and third centuries, these images include various representations of the Buddha, in standing, seated and *parinirvāṇa* postures (see



FIGURE 9.1. The Buddha and donor figures, Mount Kongwang (second–third century CE). Reprinted from Sen, *Buddhism, Diplomacy, and Trade*.

figure 9.1). They are interspersed with traditional Chinese motifs and images of human figures wearing costumes that suggest their Central Asian origins.¹⁴ Another early image of the Buddha, in seated posture, is found in a cave tomb at Ma Hao 麻浩 in Sichuan province and also dates from the late second or early third century.¹⁵ The use of Buddhist images in Chinese tombs suggests the incorporation of Buddhist imagery in the local mortuary tradition. It is not clear, however, if the patron of the tomb was aware of the identity of the figure portrayed in the image or the teachings associated with Buddhism. Wu Hung has argued that these early images should not be termed “Buddhist” given the context in which they were used. Wu Hung writes that, although at the initial stages several elements from Indian Buddhist art filtered into China, none of them had

either an inherently Buddhist content, or a Buddhist religious function. Rather, as novel forms, they served to enrich the representations of Chinese indigenous

cults and traditional ideas. It would be misleading to identify these works as early Chinese Buddhist art and take them as the true embodiment of the original Buddhist meaning. In fact, these works cannot even be seen as reflecting a fusion of Buddhism and the Chinese tradition. They only reflect a random borrowing of Buddhist elements by Han popular art. In my opinion, this was the dominant situation when Buddhist art was first introduced into China. In this tenuous way, nevertheless, Buddhist art gradually gained a foothold in a vast and unfamiliar land.¹⁶

Despite such ambiguity in the use of images in the popular realm, it is evident that by the third century Buddhist objects were being employed for their supernatural and miraculous powers, aspects that would in the next few centuries become more widespread with the translation of Buddhist texts and the visits of Chinese monks to South Asia. These early images serve as examples of the ways in which objects in motion function as agents in spreading ideas—no matter how transformed or incomplete the concepts may seem to have become—and linking far-flung regions of the world. These dynamics continued in the making and venerating of Buddhist images advocated in some of the translated texts and by the members of the monastic institutions that subsequently reached China. Images, too, especially paintings narrating the previous lives of the Buddha and representations of Buddhist “hell” and “paradise” were employed to spread the basic teachings of Buddhism, particularly those related to the ideas of karma and retribution, which were initially unfamiliar to Chinese worshipers. Some Buddhist sculptures also acquired supernatural qualities because of their perceived ability to move and have humanlike feelings, forming important narrative tropes in Chinese Buddhist miracle tales.¹⁷

The Buddhist images reaching China during the first millennium CE originated from different parts of South Asia, each with unique stylistic features and motifs. Gandhāran, Gupta, Pāla, and the artistic renditions from Nāgārjunikoṇḍa in south India were some of the major traditions that entered China. Styles that developed in Central Asia also had significant impact on the making of Buddhist images in China. These images spread through different routes and means: South Asian artisans traveled to China expressly to make Buddhist statues and paintings. Indian painters named Shijiafotuo 釋迦佛陀 (Śākyabuddha?), Juecheng 覺稱 (Buddhakīrti?), and Tongzhi 童智 (Kumārabodhi) during the Northern Wei period (386–534) are known to

have made paintings that adorned several local Buddhist monasteries.¹⁸ Similarly, a Sri Lankan monk artist in China during the Tang period made clay images of Buddhist divinities installed at monasteries in Luoyang.¹⁹ On other occasions, Chinese monks and diplomats visiting South Asia returned with Buddhist images and other artifacts. The diplomatic mission sent to South Asia in 645 and led by the Tang diplomat Wang Xuance 王玄策 (fl. seventh century) included a Chinese artisan named Song Fazhi 宋法智 (fl. seventh century) who drew several images of Buddhist figures that were subsequently replicated in China.²⁰ Buddhist drawings, rubbings, and replicas were also brought to China from India by Xuanzang 玄奘 (600?–664) and displayed prominently at the Tang capital.²¹

John Kieschnick has pointed out the importance of Buddhist images in the practice of Buddhism in China. “Images never ceased to be a central feature of Chinese Buddhist devotion.” Kieschnick specifically details the impact of Buddhist images on Chinese ideas of sacred power as well as on material culture and social relationships, and at the same time, they served to instigate debate about the legitimacy of foreign icons. Through the circulation of these images, “Buddhist symbolism,” as Kieschnick notes, “became increasingly widespread” in China.²² This included the swastika, the dharma wheel, and the lotus. The Chinese also invented their own images and modified those entering China from South Asia and elsewhere. This was often done in the process of local practitioners’ adapting of new images, as well as providing prospective converts familiar contexts to engage new practices. This combination of foreign and local helped create a dual identity for the Buddhists outside South Asia. While the foreign images helped the followers associate with the broader Buddhist world, the local innovations created a notion of the sacredness of their own land. This duality was crucial in creating and integrating the Buddhist cosmopolis.²³

Itinerant Images and the Diversity of the Buddhist Cosmopolis

Conceiving of itineraries as staged, circulatory, converging, and disjunctive helps us better understand the movement of Buddhist images across the Asian continent. These facets of itineraries have been discussed in detail in the first two chapters of this volume. Indeed, the spread of Buddhist images from South Asia to China, their transformation en route to or in China, and the subsequent transmission to other regions of East Asia and elsewhere reveal

multiple bumps and blocks, disjunctures and differences—as well as the “effort” of the local as discussed by Arjun Appadurai.²⁴ Such movements and itineraries created unique linkages and modes of circulation among different societies, their transformations and local reinterpretations suggest the convergence of distinct ideas and values, and the further spread or the reverse transmission of these transformed images denotes the circulatory itineraries of images.²⁵ A wide range of imagination, knowledge, and perceptions resulted from this process: As people living in China and Japan encountered Buddhism and new customs and practices through these images, they added fresh content and motifs, creating distinct forms and “forms of circulations.”²⁶

New types of images emerged based on the understanding and interpretations of texts that were rendered into local languages. The impact of the *Lotus Sutra* on the production of art forms in East Asia, especially Japan, is perhaps the most notable. The transmission of the text to Japan, in its Chinese translation, led not only to the creation of images related to the teachings contained in the work but also to the production of art forms that portrayed the lifestyle of the aristocratic class who were the main sponsors of the artists illustrating the text.²⁷ Images also ceased to travel when cultural norms of a region prevented the spread of certain iconographic styles. This is evident from the abrupt cessation of iconographies of bare-chested female figures drawn in Indic style found at the Kizil caves in the Kucha region of present-day Xinjiang province. Chinese aesthetics with regard to the depiction of female bodies in art form seems to have blocked the eastward spread of such representations.²⁸

Other than a few exceptional periods such as during the Northern Qi (550–577) when attempts were made to closely copy Indic styles, Buddhist images produced in China mostly followed local aesthetics and traditions, serving both religious and secular purposes.²⁹ Although, for example, paintings on the walls of caves such as those in Dunhuang incorporated local motifs and styles to propagate the doctrine or express the faith of the followers, Buddhist statues allegedly created in the likeness of Empress Wu Zetian 武則天 (r. 690–705), who usurped the Tang throne in the seventh century, were built to promote political legitimization.³⁰ A result of efforts to produce localized forms of Buddhist art meant that, by the seventh century, China emerged as a leading producer and exporter of Buddhist images. The art produced during this period is, as Dorothy Wong notes, sometimes referred to as the “Tang International Buddhist Art Style,” which was “a synthesis in both style and



FIGURE 9.2. Star mandala from Japan (late seventeenth century). Gift of the Friends of the Philadelphia Museum of Art (1978-45-2). Philadelphia Museum of Art.

content of fresh influences from India and the existing tradition of Buddhist art in China that had developed since the fifth century.”³¹

Wong points out that this “Tang International Buddhist Art Style” was preceded by the “first” international Buddhist art style beginning “with the Gupta (fourth–sixth centuries) style achieved in the fifth century in centers such as Mathurā and Sārnāth, which then became the classic idiom copied throughout Asia.” Wong also suggests the emergence of a “third” international Buddhist style, the “Pāla International Style,” derived from “the Gupta style prevailed from Nepal to Tibet, Myanmar, Thailand, and Indonesia from the eighth through the 13th century and beyond.”³² Although these three “international” styles of Buddhist art appeared during different periods, they often mixed, intermingled, moved, and converged in different directions and sites.

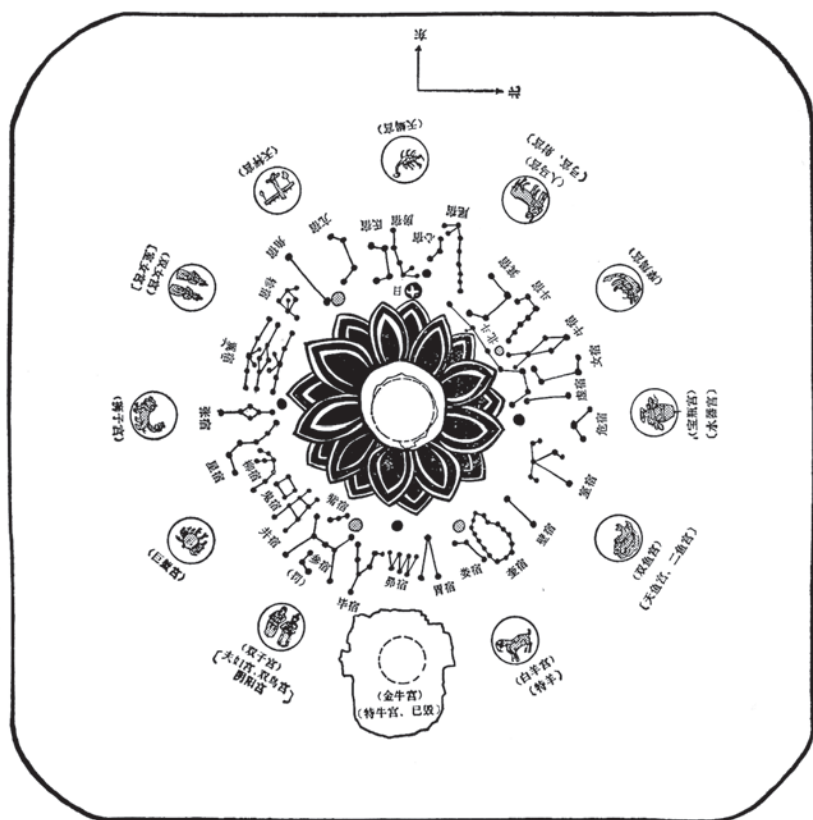


FIGURE 9.3. Astronomical diagram from the Xuanhua Tombs (twelfth century). Reprinted from Sen, "Astronomical Tomb Paintings." After Hebei sheng wenwu guanlichu (Hebei Cultural Relics Administrative Department) and Hebei sheng bowuguan (Hebei Provincial Museum), "Hebei Xuanhua Liao bihuamu fajue jianbao" (A brief report on the excavation of a Liao painted tomb from Xuanhua, Hebei), *Wenwu* 8 (1975): 31–39, 44.

Many of the images associated with Tantric teachings popular in East Asia between the seventh and tenth centuries, for example, were influenced by the Pāla style. However, the clergy in Tang China and Japan modified and created their own rendition of these images, which mixed local ideas, beliefs, and motifs. The mandalic representation of the cosmos, wrathful Tantric deities, and even the mantras (*dharanis*) written in Indic script that emerged from such mixtures were powerful images employed in rituals, ceremonies, and mortuary practices in several regions of East and Southeast Asia. In fact, as Hiram Woodward has demonstrated, there were similarities and mutual influences

between Tantric images produced in Tang-Song China, Tibet, Cambodia, and Java.³³ In the case of Java, Woodward suggests the possibility of a local monk named Bianhong 辯弘 in Chinese sources contributing to the design of the upper terraces of Borobudur based on the knowledge he acquired studying under the Tantric masters in Tang China during the late eighth century.³⁴

Tantric ideas emitting from Tang China were also responsible for the creation of new varieties of images in Japan. In the seventh–eighth centuries, the Japanese developed unique ways of representing the Buddhist cosmos through paintings known as the Star Maṇḍalas (in Japanese, *Hoshi mandara* 星曼陀羅) (see figure 9.2). Employed in Tantric Buddhist rituals, maṇḍalas are viewed as connecting devotees to the materiality of the universe. The Star Maṇḍalas, with representations of celestial objects frequently in anthropomorphic forms, originated from Tantric Buddhist texts containing synthesized Hellenistic and Brahmanical ideas on astronomy and astrology. These texts were rendered into Chinese by Indian monks working in Tang China and rapidly gained acceptance throughout East Asia especially because of the state patronage of Tantric Buddhism. The diagrams are manifestations of the convergence of different ideas and traditions, some of which spread with Buddhism and others that arrived or developed locally in China and Japan independently. These Japanese diagrams entered the streams of Tantric circulations in East Asia, were transmitted back to the clergy in China, and had significant impact on the lay believers of Buddhism. During the eleventh and twelfth centuries, for instance, images derived from these diagrams found their way into the tombs belonging to Han Chinese residents of the Khitan (Liao) Empire.³⁵ These tomb paintings (see figure 9.3) are also evidence of the enduring feature of East Asian Buddhist practices, starting from the Han tombs at Ma Hao, that mixed the teachings of Buddhism with Sinitic mortuary traditions.

There were other images produced in China, and not associated with Tantric Buddhism, that traveled across several regions of the Buddhist world. These included the representations of the Chan/Zen monk Bodhidharma, the bodhisattvas Dizang 地藏 and Guanyin 觀音, and the so-called laughing Buddha named Budai (in Japanese, Hotei) 布袋. The creation of these images and their associated cults indicate the local character of Buddhism and the importance of China as a center for disseminating Buddhist doctrines and iconographies. The image of the famous Buddhist divinity Mañjuśrī (Wen-shushili 文殊師利) riding a lion may have originated in China and spread to all parts of the Buddhist world (see figure 9.4), indeed, even monks from



FIGURE 9.4. The Buddhist divinity Mañjuśrī. (Dunhuang, ninth century). © Trustees of the British Museum.

South Asia believed that this “bodhisattva of wisdom” lived on the Chinese mountain Wutai and traveled there expressly to pay obeisance.³⁶ Paintings of Mañjuśrī and maps of Mount Wutai 五臺山 were produced for local consumption and for export to places such as Tibet, Japan, Nepal, and India. The widespread acceptance of Mount Wutai as the abode of Mañjuśrī validated the integration of China into the Buddhist realm and legitimized its status as a center for the transmission of Buddhist ideas and images.³⁷

Similar to the story of the Han Emperor Ming’s dream, the official introduction of Buddhism to Japan is also associated with an account that involves the local ruler and an image. In 538, a bronze image of the Buddha and other artifacts were gifted to reigning Japanese Emperor Kinmei 欽明天皇 (r. 539–571) by diplomats sent by the ruler of the Korean polity called Paekche. The bronze image, which most likely originated in either China or Korea, soon became a significant element of the legend as it was said to have miraculously reappeared after being discarded in a river.³⁸ The story gave the presence of Buddhism in Japan a founding genealogy—and one associated with the ruler—while it incorporated yet another region into the Buddhist realm. With Buddhism established in Japan, an effervescing and multidirectional interaction of Buddhist objects, images, and ideas ensued in East Asia. Ideas and objects locally produced in the region not only circulated between China, Korea, and Japan but also influenced the seminomadic societies and polities in Central and northwestern Asia, as well as parts of Southeast Asia. The emergence of an East Asian sphere did not terminate Buddhist circulation to and from South Asia. Monks from Korea visited India to procure religious texts, images, and relics, and Buddhist missionaries from South Asian monastic institutions such as Nālandā continued to travel to China and Korea as late as the fourteenth century.³⁹

Unlike their Chinese and Korean counterparts, Japanese monks did not visit Buddhist sites in South Asia until the sixteenth century. However, their longings for the Buddhist holy land can be discerned from a series of images they created to visually represent the geography, peoples, and even the Chinese monks visiting the holy land in South Asia. By the fourteenth century, if not earlier, the Japanese were making maps of India based on the seventh-century travel records of the Chinese monk Xuanzang (see figure 1.8a–b in chapter 1, this volume). They also created visual representations of famous South Asian monks, including those who were active in China. The most intriguing of these are the images of the Tang monk’s meetings with

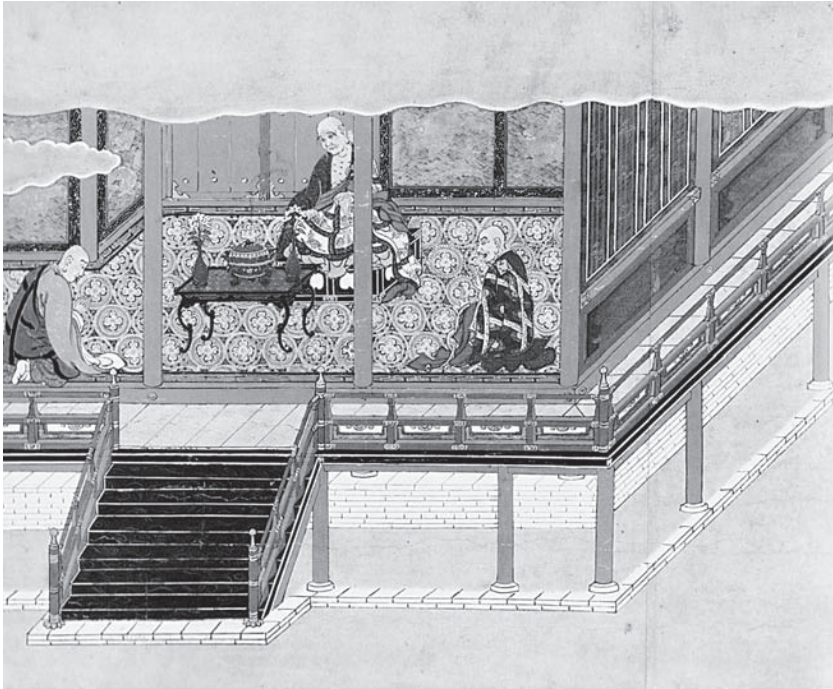


FIGURE 9.5. Xuanzang at Nālandā (fourteenth century). After Rambelli, “The Idea of India,” and reprinted from Sen, *Buddhism across Asia*.

the South Asian ruler Harṣa and his teachers at Nālandā (figure 9.5).⁴⁰ All of these representations were imagined, often mediated through Chinese texts, and expressed the longing for and belonging to a Buddhist world that were felt by Japanese worshippers. Like the Star Maṇḍalas, these are examples of images on the move, albeit not physically but, rather, as part of the imagination of distant, yet interconnected, locales in the Buddhist cosmopolis.

Almost at the same time as these images were circulating in East Asia, Mongol Iran was intimately in contact with various parts of South Asia and China. The Ilkhanate official and prolific author Rashīd al-Dīn in *Jamī al-Tavārikh* (World history) composed in the fourteenth century included a section on the biography of the Buddha. He based this “Life and Teachings of the Buddha” on information provided by a Kashmiri monk named Kamalāśrī and two Chinese informants. One of the existing manuscripts of this work, dated 1314, contains three images from the life of the Buddha: the scene of temptation (see figure 9.7d below), where the evil Mara attempts to prevent

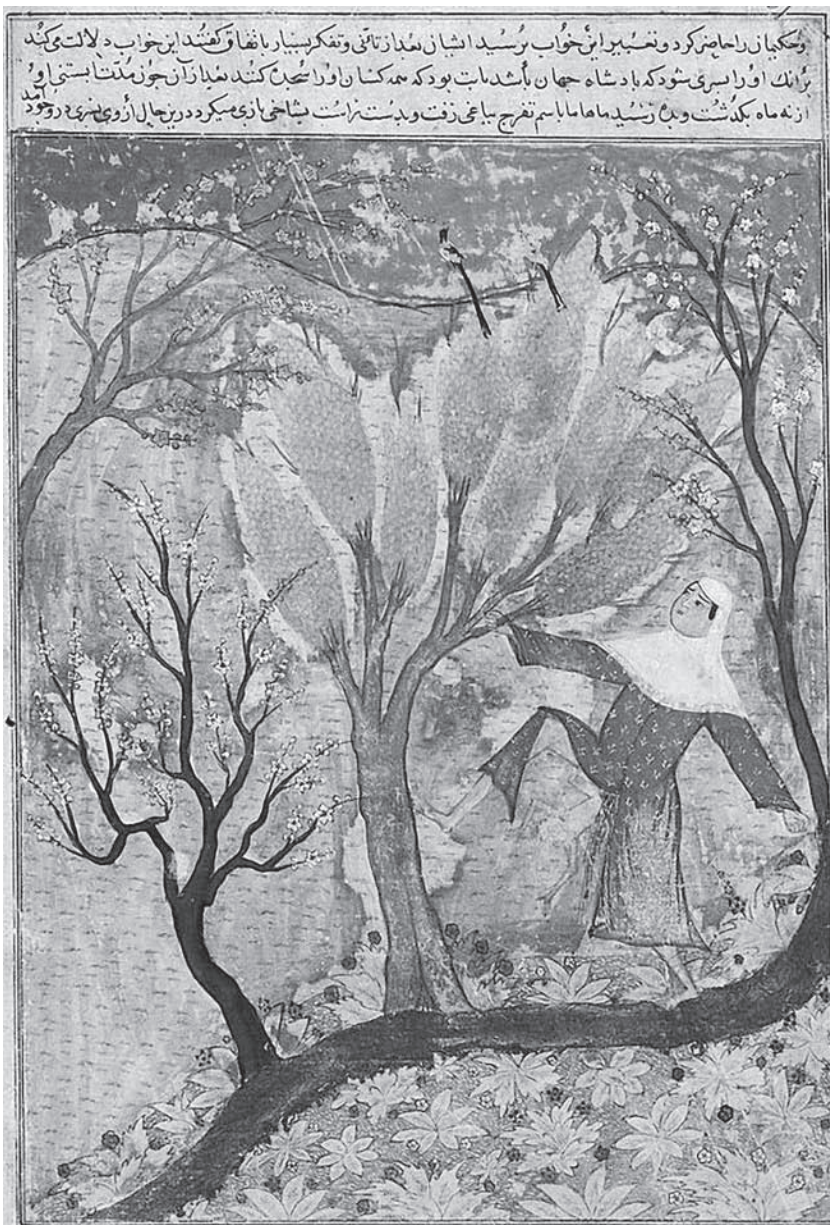


FIGURE 9.6. The birth of the Buddha, illustrated version from *Majma al-tavarikh* (fifteenth century). The Walters Art Museum, Baltimore, Maryland. Public domain.

the Buddha from attaining enlightenment; the Jetavana monastery, where the Buddha preached; and the holy site Kuśinagara, where the Buddha attained nirvana.⁴¹ Two centuries later, paintings of the Buddha appeared in Hafiz-i Abru's *Majma al-tavarikh* (Chronicles). Much of the information on the Buddha's life in this later text was copied from Rashīd al-Dīn's work, but the illustrations, the birth of the Buddha (figure 9.6), Buddha's meeting with a Brahmin, and his nirvana are different in content and style when compared to the illustrated manuscript of *Jami al-Tavarikh*. They are more similar to the Japanese representations of an imagined India, yet another example of the accretive and looping itineraries of objects, images, and ideas in the multicultural, interconnected, and imagined cosmopolis of Buddhism.

Conclusion

The circulation of Buddhist images continued even after the colonization of Asia by European powers. In fact, in the late eighteenth and nineteenth centuries, Buddhist images from China were introduced into India by Chinese immigrants. These immigrants, numbering around sixteen hundred in 1901, had settled primarily in Calcutta (now Kolkata), the capital of British India, and they built several Chinese temples and shrines, including some dedicated to the Guanyin. They also brought with them images of Ruan Ziyu 阮子鬱 (1079–1102) and Liang Cineng 梁慈能 (1098–1116), two localized Chinese Buddhist divinities whose temples originated in the Sihui region of Guangdong province. The images of these two buddhas had spread to present-day Malaysia, then from there they reached Calcutta. Members of the Chinese immigrant community also built temples in several other holy Buddhist sites in India and had statues of the Buddha and other divinities, such as the Guanyin, imported from China or Myanmar. These Chinese Buddhist temples and shrines indicate how durable and persistent the circulations of Buddhist images were.⁴²

In the colonial period Buddhist images and artifacts also traveled not only as part of religious practice but also as part of the attempt to collect, catalog, and curate antiquities from the colonized world. Like other dimensions of the larger colonial enterprise intending to demonstrate imperial power and European cultural superiority over the ancient (and then weakened) Asian civilizations, these activities included the excavation of historical sites, the removal of objects from their original sites—purportedly to preserve them as well as for their display at museums and exhibitions around the world.⁴³ The British, for example, removed a significant number of Buddhist statutes, inscriptions, and



FIGURE 9.7A. The assault of Mara (with aniconic representation of the Buddha). Amaravati (second century). Wikimedia, Creative Commons, public domain. <https://commons.wikimedia.org/wiki/File:MaraAssault.jpg>.



FIGURE 9.7B. Dunhuang rendition of the assault of Mara (tenth century). MG 17655, Guimet Museum. Wikimedia, Creative Commons, public domain.
[https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Mara_\(demon\)#/media/File:Dunhuang_Mara_Budda.jpg](https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Mara_(demon)#/media/File:Dunhuang_Mara_Budda.jpg).



FIGURE 9.7C. Modern rendition of the assault of Mara story in Burmese style in a Buddhist temple in Penang, Malaysia. Wikimedia, Creative Commons. Public domain. https://commons.wikimedia.org/wiki/File:Mara_demon_nat_and_Buddha.jpg.

paintings from Central and Southeast Asia and moved them to their empire in India or transported them to galleries in England. The French, Germans, and all other imperial powers, including the Japanese, employed similar methods with comparable objectives. A large number of objects were also smuggled from Asian sites and sold at auction houses in Europe and the United States. Some of these colonial collections and stolen objects are now being returned to the countries of origin, sustaining, in certain ways, the circulatory journeys of Buddhist images and artifacts.⁴⁴

So Buddhist images followed complicated itineraries, moving initially from South Asia to China, where they underwent local transformations and reentered new paths of circulation. Iranians, Chinese, Southeast Asians, and several other groups of people contributed their own local aesthetics and meanings to Buddhist iconography during this process of circulation. The four final images (figures 9.7a–d) of the evil Mara’s encounters with the Buddha prior to the Buddha’s enlightenment, each coming from a different cultural sphere, illustrate the resultant local character and diversity of artistic representations in the Buddhist world. They also show the connectivities among the four regions through the employment of similar motifs. It was argued that in order to understand and trace the itineraries of Buddhist images, a broad canvas of geographical space and temporal framework is needed. The use of such spatial and temporal analysis reveals the contribution of itinerant images in integrating the Buddhist cosmopolis that encompassed most of Asia.



FIGURE 9.7D. Persian rendition of the assault of Mara (fourteenth century). Wikimedia, Creative Commons. Public domain. https://commons.wikimedia.org/wiki/File:Jami_al-Tawarikh_001.jpg.

Anthropologists have demonstrated that the demand, desire, control, and value of goods may lead to commodities taking on “life cycles” of their own.⁴⁵ Others have emphasized the “agency of objects” in creating new contexts and courses of action.⁴⁶ The itineraries, or “life cycles” of Buddhist images included transmission, modification, transformation, further movement, and sometimes return to original sites of creation in new forms. The “life cycles” also pertained to the changes in the medium of expression, from texts to paintings or vice versa, for instance, as well as the contexts within which the images were placed—cave temples, monastic institutions, homes, royal palaces, or museums. As Buddhist images moved from one place to another and took on new shapes, meanings, and contexts, they triggered imaginations, fostered knowledge, and created fresh linkages within and across several societies. Through such processes, far-flung regions, where Buddhism was interpreted and practiced in diverse ways, became integrated, thus linking the Buddhist cosmopolis not only through faith in the teachings of the Buddha and the pilgrimages and the missionary work of the Buddhist monks but also through the itineraries and life cycles of images that sustained these linkages.